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CALL OF THE BALLOT Voters in Uttar Pradesh during the 2019 Lok Sabha polls

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

ONE NATION, ONE POLL

ONE-CLICK REPUBLIC

By Amarnath K. Menon

On September 1, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led National Democratic Alliance government appointed an eight-man committee headed by former president Ram Nath Kovind to examine and suggest the way forward for its One Nation, One Poll (ONOP) proposal. Just two days later—on a Sunday—law ministry officials briefed Kovind on the constitutional provisions pertaining to the proposal and discussed what kind of assistance his committee may need to look into the subject. Many also speculated that ONOP could be the surprise awaited in the upcoming special session of Parliament between September 18-22. If not haste, that's certainly extraordinary persistence on the part of the BJP.

With the Lok Sabha polls due in less than a year, Opposition parties have raised apprehensions about the move, stating that conducting simultaneous polls will spell disaster for India's multi-party framework and thrust the country into a presidential system of governance. They also point to bias in the composition of the committee and believe the real intent is to push through laws that will ultimately benefit only Narendra Modi and enable his government to evade accountabil-